

Divine Omnipotence

doc-divine-omnipotence

Theology Proper · Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

God is all-powerful, able to do all that He wills, limited only by His own nature.

In plain language

The vocabulary the Bible uses for God's all-power is dense and remarkably consistent across the whole canon. In Hebrew, the verb 'to be too wonderful or too hard' (pala') appears as a fixed rhetorical question, with God as the one for whom no matter is too hard, at Genesis 18:14, Jeremiah 32:17, Jeremiah 32:27, and Zechariah 8:6, each time in the same grammatical form (the Hebrew passive form, called niphal, under a 'is it the case that' question marker). At Job 42:2 the words 'you are able' (yakol) paired with the universal 'all' (kol) and the statement that no plan can be withheld (negated 'to withhold', batsar) from you predicate unrestricted capacity. The title 'God Almighty' (El Shadday) names God by overwhelming sufficiency, and the outstretched arm ('outstretched arm', zeroa' netuyah) at Jeremiah 32:17 ties creating power to covenant action. Strikingly, the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint, translates 'Almighty' (Shadday) and 'Lord of hosts' (Sabaoth) by 'ruler of all' or 'Almighty' (pantokrator), which then becomes a fixed title in Revelation, so the same word-thread runs from Genesis to the last book. In Greek, Luke 1:37 says no 'word' or 'matter' (rhema) will be impossible ('to be impossible', adynateo) from God, and Matthew 19:26, Mark 10:27, and Luke 18:27 repeat that with God all things are possible (the contrast of 'impossible', adynatos, against 'possible', dynatos, with universal 'all', pas). So the affirmation lands as true with high confidence: the terms recur, span every section of the canon, and the grammar is stable. Where readers diverge, the reason is also in the words. This vocabulary speaks about tasks and purposes and never addresses whether God could contradict himself. The canon marks that gap from inside: Hebrews 6:18 says it is impossible (adynatos again) for God to lie and 2 Timothy 2:13 says he cannot ('cannot', ou dynamai) deny himself, which are limits set by his own nature, not failures of power. Because the words affirm a category without delimiting its scope against self-contradiction, careful readers add the qualifier 'limited only by His own nature', and the small remaining debate (such as whether God may leave future free choices open) is about that scope, not about whether God is all-powerful.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0410	אל	el	God	
H0657	אָפּ	ephes	end	
H1219	בָּצַר	batsar	to gather/restrain/fortify	35
H1697	דָּבַר	davar	word	
H2220	זְרוּעַ	zeroa'	arm	82
H3027	יָד	yad	hand	
H3201	יָכֹל	yakol	be able	183

H3605	כֹּל	kol	all	5,049
H3808	לֹא	loʾ	not	4,825
H4209	מַזְמִינָה	mezimmah	plot	18
H5186	נָטַח	natah	to stretch	195
H5869	עַיִן	ayin	eye	
H6381	אֵלָּא	palaʾ	to wonder	66
H6635	צָבָא	tsava	army	
H7114	קָצֵר	qatser	be short	
H7706	שֹׁדֵד	Shadday	Almighty	47
G0101	ἀδυνατέω	adynateo	be impossible	2
G0102	ἀδύνατος	adynatos	unable	10
G1415	δυνατός	dynatos	able	32
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G3756	οὐ	ou	no	1,747
G3841	παντοκράτωρ	pantokrator	almighty	10
G3844	παρά	para	from/with/beside	196
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,316
G4487	ῥῆμα	rhema	declaration	71

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The canon predicates exhaustive divine capability through a stable recurring formula that pairs a negation (a 'not' word) with a universal (an 'all' or 'every' word). In Hebrew the verb H6381 'to be too wonderful or too hard' (palaʾ) stands as a niphāl imperfect (the Hebrew passive form, ongoing or repeated action) under an interrogative he (a 'is it the case that' question marker), asking rhetorically whether any matter is too wonderful or too hard for the LORD (Genesis 18:14, Jeremiah 32:17, Jeremiah 32:27, Zechariah 8:6), and at Job 42:2 H3201 'to be able' (yakol, you are able) is paired with universal H3605 'all' (kol) while the negated niphāl (passive form) of H1219 'to withhold or restrain' (batsar) declares no purpose can be withheld from God. The title H7706 'Almighty' (El Shadday) names God by overwhelming sufficiency. In Greek the same pattern is lexicalized by G0101 'to be impossible' (adynateo) negated at Luke 1:37 with universal G3956 'all' or 'every' (pas) and the source genitive (the 'from-X' grammatical form) G3844 'from' (para tou theou, from God), and by the formula 'all things are possible with God' (panta dynata para to theo) at Matthew 19:26, Mark 10:27, and Luke 18:27. The Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint, renders 'Almighty' (Shadday) and 'of hosts' (Sabaoth) by G3841 'Almighty' or 'ruler of all' (pantokrator), which recurs as a divine title across 2 Corinthians 6:18 and Revelation, binding the Testaments lexically (in their word-choices). Cross-genre, multi-section attestation with consistent semantics (meaning that holds steady across passages) yields a high-confidence affirmation, with the one open edge being that this vocabulary speaks to tasks and purposes and is silent on self-contradiction, which the canon itself marks at Hebrews 6:18 and 2 Timothy 2:13.

Scripture

Gen.17.1 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7706 אֱלֹהִים, H0410 אֵל.

Force. Self-disclosure formula 'God Almighty' (אֱלֹהִים, El Shadday) names God by an attribute of overwhelming sufficiency and power, framing the Abrahamic covenant grant. Of the 47 occurrences of 'Almighty' (Shadday), 31 cluster in Job and the rest in patriarchal Genesis (Genesis 28:3, 35:11, 43:14, 48:3, 49:25) and Exodus 6:3, where the title is the covenant self-designation. The Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint, regularly renders 'Almighty' (Shadday) by 'ruler of all' (pantokrator), lexically binding (in word-choice) this title to the New Testament Almighty.

Job.42.2 · for · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3201 יָכֹל, H1219 בָּצַר; H4209 מְצֻמָּה, H3605 כָּל.

Force. Job confesses 'you are able of all' (תִּנְכַּל-כָּל; qal imperfect 2ms of 'to be able' (yakol), so the simple active form of the Hebrew verb in ongoing action, second person masculine singular, paired with universal 'all' (kol)) paired with the negated niph'al 'shall be withheld' (יִבָּצֵר, the Hebrew passive form: no plan can be restrained from you). The pairing of 'to be able' (yakol) plus universal 'all' (kol) with negated 'to withhold' (batsar) of 'plan' or 'purpose' (mezimmah) predicates unrestricted capacity and unfrustratable purpose (a purpose that cannot be blocked). Note that 'to withhold' (batsar) is dominantly used elsewhere of fortified or inaccessible cities (its sense at Genesis 11:6, the same niph'al imperfect, the Hebrew passive form in ongoing action, is applied to human builders), so the omnipotence (all-power) force here rests on the universal subject and the divine addressee, not on the verb in isolation.

Gen.18.14 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H6381 פֶּלֶא; H1697 דָּבַר.

Force. The rhetorical question 'is any matter too hard for the LORD' (הֲיִפְלֵא מִיְהוָה דְּבַר; interrogative he, a 'is it the case that' question marker, plus niph'al imperfect 3ms of 'to be too wonderful or too hard' (pala'), so the Hebrew passive form in ongoing action, third person masculine singular: is any 'matter' or 'word' (davar) too wonderful or too hard for the LORD) introduces the formula at the Isaac annunciation (the announcement of Isaac's birth). The niph'al (passive form) of 'to be too wonderful' (pala') with the interrogative he (question marker) is the fixed grammatical shape of the question. The expected answer is no.

Jer.32.17 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: idiom

Key terms. H6381 פֶּלֶא; H3808 לֹא, H2220 זָרַע, H5186 גֹּטֶה, H3605 כָּל.

Force. Jeremiah's prayer combines creation language (heaven and earth made by the outstretched arm, זָרַע וְגֹטֶה, 'outstretched arm' (zeroa' netuyah)) with the negated niph'al (passive form) 'no matter is too hard from you' (כָּל-דְּבַר; יִפְלֵא מִמֶּנִּי: no 'matter' or 'word' (davar) with respect to 'all' (kol) is too wonderful or too hard from you). The outstretched arm is a stock collocation (a fixed word-combination) for divine power-in-action, recurring across Deuteronomy and Exodus. The niph'al imperfect of 'to be too wonderful' (pala'), so the Hebrew passive form in ongoing action, matches Genesis 18:14.

Jer.32.27 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6381 פֶּלֶא; H3605 כָּל.

Force. God's reply uses the same 'to be too wonderful' (pala') niph'al (the Hebrew passive form) in a self-referential rhetorical question, 'is any matter too hard for me' (הֲיִפְלֵא מִמֶּנִּי; is any 'matter' or 'word' (davar) with respect to 'all' (kol) too hard for me), restating the prayer's logic from the divine side and confirming the predication. The pairing with universal 'all' (kol) again scopes the claim to every matter.

Zech.8.6 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6381 פלא, H5869 עין.

Force. Even if a thing is too wonderful (פלא, the same 'to be too wonderful' (pala') niphal, the Hebrew passive form) in the eyes of the remnant, will it also be too wonderful in my eyes, says the LORD of hosts. The doubled niphal (doubled passive form) contrasts human estimation of impossibility with the divine perspective, the same logic that Luke 18:27 lexicalizes (puts into words) in Greek.

Num.11.23 · for · genre: narrative · figures: idiom

Key terms. H3027 יד, H7114 קצר.

Force. The LORD answers Moses with 'is the LORD's hand too short' (יְהוָה יְקוֹרֵת קָצָר, interrogative he, a 'is it the case that' question marker, plus qal imperfect of 'to be short' (qatsar), so the simple active form of the Hebrew verb in ongoing action: is the LORD's hand too short). The shortened-hand idiom is a second rhetorical-question power formula parallel to the 'to be too wonderful' (pala') pattern, predicating sufficient reach for any promised act.

Luke.1.37 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0101 ἀδυνατέω, G3956 πᾶς, G3844 παρά, G4487 ῥῆμα

Force. Gabriel echoes Genesis 18:14 with 'no word will be impossible from God' (οὐκ ἀδυνατήσει παρὰ τοῦ θεοῦ πᾶν ῥῆμα: every 'word' or 'matter' (rhema) will not be impossible from God). The verb 'to be impossible' (adynateo) stands as a future active indicative 3rd singular (a simple future statement of fact, third person singular) negated by 'not' (ouk), with universal 'all' or 'every' (pas) and the source genitive (the 'from-X' grammatical form) 'from God' (para tou theou) locating the impossibility-of-failure in God. 'To be impossible' (adynateo) occurs only twice in the New Testament (here and Matthew 17:20), so its sense is read from these two contexts and from the Septuagint (the Greek Old Testament) of Genesis 18:14, not triangulated across many uses.

Matt.19.26 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0102 ἀδύνατος, G1415 δυνατός, G3956 πᾶς, G3844 παρά

Force. 'With men this is impossible, but with God all things are possible' (παρὰ ἀνθρώποις τοῦτο ἀδύνατόν ἐστιν, παρὰ δὲ θεῷ πάντα δυνατά). The antithesis (the deliberate contrast) sets 'impossible' (adynatos) against 'possible' or 'able' (dynatos) and scopes the divine side with universal neuter plural 'all things' (panta). The 'with' or 'from' (para) plus dative (the 'to/for-X' grammatical form) construction marks the sphere in which the capacity holds.

Mark.10.27 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1415 δυνατός, G3956 πᾶς, G3844 παρά, G3756 οὐ

Force. 'Impossible with men but not with God, for all things are possible with God' (παρὰ ἀνθρώποις ἀδύνατον ἀλλ' οὐ παρὰ θεῷ, πάντα γὰρ δυνατὰ παρὰ τῷ θεῷ). The doubled 'with' or 'from' (para) plus dative (the 'to/for-X' grammatical form) and the universal 'all things are possible' (panta dynata) restate the Matthean formula, and the explanatory 'for' (gar) makes the universal-possibility clause the ground of the whole saying.

Luke.18.27 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0102 ἀδύνατος, G1415 δυνατός, G3844 παρά, G2316 θεός

Force. 'The things impossible with men are possible with God' (τὰ ἀδύνατα παρὰ ἀνθρώποις δυνατὰ παρὰ τῷ θεῷ ἐστίν). The substantival neuter plural 'impossible things' (adynata, used as a noun) set against 'possible things' (dynata) predicates capable status of all such matters from God's side, mirroring Matthew 19:26 and Mark 10:27 and the Lukan annunciation (the announcement to Mary) lexeme (word-form).

Rev.19.6 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G3841 παντοκράτωρ, G2316 θεός

Force. 'The Lord God the Almighty reigns' (ἐβασίλευσεν κύριος ὁ θεὸς ὁ παντοκράτωρ). 'Almighty' or 'ruler of all' (pantokrator), the Septuagint (Greek Old Testament) rendering of 'Almighty' (Shadday) and 'of hosts' (Sabaoth), is a fixed divine title in Revelation (nine of its ten New Testament occurrences) and binds the reigning verb 'to reign' (basileuo) to the all-ruling title. The term joins exhaustive power to sovereign dominion (ruler of all), so its force is title and rule as much as raw capacity.

Isa.46.9 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H0410 לֹא, H0657 אֲחֵר

Force. I am God and there is none else ('none like me', הֵנִי כִּי, with 'none' or 'no other' ('efes)), grounding omnipotence (all-power) in incomparability rather than in the power vocabulary directly. The negation-plus-universal logic continues in the second-Isaiah self-disclosure series, where the same outstretched-hand and creation language of Jeremiah 32:17 recurs (Isaiah 44:24, 45:12).

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gen.17.1	Gen.18.14	tsk	1
Jer.32.17	Jer.32.27	openbible	1
Jer.32.17	Job.42.2	openbible	1
Jer.32.17	Gen.18.14	openbible	1
Job.42.2	Gen.18.14	tsk	1
Job.42.2	Job.23.13	tsk	1
Luke.1.37	Gen.18.14	openbible	1
Luke.1.37	Jer.32.27	openbible	1
Luke.1.37	Matt.19.26	openbible	1
Luke.1.37	Mark.10.27	openbible	1
Luke.1.37	Luke.18.27	openbible	1
Luke.1.37	Num.11.23	openbible	1
Luke.1.37	Zech.8.6	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Heb.6.18 · addressed

'It is impossible for God to lie' (ἐν οἷς ἀδύνατον ψεύσασθαι θεόν) predicates an impossibility of God lying, using the same 'impossible' (adynatos) stem (G0102) as the omnipotence (all-power) affirmations of Matthew 19:26 and Luke 18:27. Lexically (in word-choice terms) this is a constraint internal to God's nature, not an external limit on power. It marks from inside the canon the very scope the power vocabulary leaves silent, and harmonizes with the stem qualifier 'limited only by His own nature' rather than contradicting all-power.

2Tim.2.13 · addressed

'He cannot deny himself' (ἀρνήσασθαι γὰρ ἑαυτὸν οὐ δύναται) predicates a nature-internal constraint using 'cannot' (ou dynamai, negated 'to be able'), the negated cognate (related word-form) of 'able' (dynatos) affirmed of God elsewhere. Consistent with the stem qualifier on the scope of capability, and the inability is moral self-consistency, not deficiency of power.

Matt.17.20 · addressed

'Nothing will be impossible for you' (οὐδὲν ἀδυνατήσει ὑμῖν) is the only other New Testament use of 'to be impossible' (adynateo) (G0101) besides Luke 1:37, and here 'nothing will be impossible' is said of the disciples acting in faith, not of God directly. This shows the verb is not lexically (in its word-choice) reserved for God, so the omnipotence (all-power) force at Luke 1:37 rests on the source genitive (the 'from-X' grammatical form) 'from God' (para tou theou), which fixes God as the one for whom no word fails.

Mark.6.5 · addressed

'He could not do there any mighty work' (οὐκ ἐδύνατο ἐκεῖ ποιῆσαι οὐδεμίαν δύναμιν) reports Jesus could do no mighty work there because of unbelief. The narrative immediately notes he healed a few sick, so the imperfect (ongoing or repeated past action) describes contextual fittingness within the unbelief, not absolute metaphysical incapacity (an inability built into the nature of reality).

Judg.1.19 · addressed

Statement that Judah could not drive out the inhabitants of the plain because they had chariots of iron concerns human agency under covenant conditions, not divine capability. The Hebrew subject of the inability is Judah, not YHWH (the LORD).

Gen.11.6 · addressed

'Now nothing will be withheld from them' (וְעַתָּה לֹא יִבְצֹר מֵהֶם) uses the identical negated niphil imperfect (Hebrew passive form in ongoing action) of 'to withhold' (batsar) (H1219) found at Job 42:2, but here 'nothing will be withheld from them' is said of the human builders at Babel. This confirms that the unfrustratable-purpose force of 'to withhold' (batsar) is not exclusive to God lexically (in its word-choice), so Job 42:2 establishes divine omnipotence (all-power) by its universal 'all' (kol) and divine addressee, not by the verb alone.

Concordance traversed

H7706, H6381, H1219, H3201, H4209, H2220, H5186, H3605, H3808, H3027, H7114, H6635, G0101, G0102, G1415, G3841, G3956, G3844, G4487, G3756

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

luke-1-37-rhema-vs-pragma at Luke.1.37: impact none. Manuscript witnesses vary between 'word' or 'matter' (ῥῆμα, rhema) and 'matter' or 'thing' (πρᾶγμα, pragma) at the close of Luke 1:37. Either reading preserves the structure 'will not be impossible from God any' (ouk adynatesei para tou theou pan) plus a referent for 'matter' or 'word', so the universal-negation logic and the verdict are unaffected.

The New Testament anchors (the core texts being analyzed) are outside the published ECM volumes (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants), which cover 3 John only. The Old Testament anchors are not in ECM scope. Greek readings checked against the MACULA-Greek Nestle1904 and SBLGNT editions in the lexical store, which agree at all anchor words.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, dispensationalism, open_theism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenant_theology: affirms · 'God Almighty' (El Shadday) at Genesis 17:1 and the outstretched arm at Jeremiah 32:17 ground omnipotence (all-power) in covenant-making and creating capability, and the Septuagint (Greek Old Testament) 'ruler of all' (pantokrator) that renders 'Almighty' (Shadday) carries the same title into the New Testament. The lexical chain (the word-chain) is read continuously across the Testaments.

dispensationalism: affirms · The same negation-plus-universal pattern is acknowledged across the dispensations (the distinct eras in this reading). No reading partition disturbs the predication of unrestricted capacity to God, and

the Revelation 'ruler of all' (pantokrator) title is read as the consummate (final and complete) disclosure of the Almighty.

classical-theism-with-nature-limit: affirms · Reads the power vocabulary as exhaustive over every possible task and purpose, while taking Hebrews 6:18 and 2 Timothy 2:13 to show the canon itself excludes self-contradiction and self-denial from the scope. The stem qualifier 'limited only by His own nature' states this directly, so all-power and the inability to lie are not in tension.

open_theism: qualified · Affirms omnipotence (all-power) as capacity in its strongest form but argues God may voluntarily self-limit in relation to the future free acts of creatures, so that some future contingents (uncertain future outcomes) are not objects of present exhaustive control. This reading grants every text cited here, since the negated 'to be too wonderful' (pala') and 'to be impossible' (adynateo) speak to God's ability and to the certainty of his promised word, and the vocabulary does not by itself adjudicate (settle) whether God has chosen to leave creaturely futures open. Job 42:2, where no 'plan' or 'purpose' (mezimmah) of God can be restrained, presses against the open reading but is about God's own purpose rather than creaturely contingency.

The stem (the question phrasing under test) includes the qualifier 'limited only by His own nature'. The lexical witness (the witness from the original-language vocabulary) at Hebrews 6:18 and 2 Timothy 2:13 supplies exactly that nature-internal boundary, removing self-contradiction and self-denial from the scope of the predication. The divergence among lenses is about scope, not about whether God is all-powerful.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The stem (the question phrasing under test) 'all-powerful, able to do all that He wills, limited only by His own nature' does not embed tradition-specific terminology. The nature-internal qualifier it carries is the plain reading of the canon's own boundary texts (Hebrews 6:18, 2 Timothy 2:13) rather than an imported philosophical taxonomy (an outside category system), so the verdict is derived honestly from the lexical (vocabulary) pattern. Verdict unchanged from the prior file.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.18.14
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Job.42.2
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Jer.32.17
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.11.6
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Num.11.23
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Luke.1.37
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.19.26
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.10.27
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6381
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1219
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H7706
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0101
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3841
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Luke.1.37
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Mark.10.27
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rev.19.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Job.42.2

cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Luke.1.37
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.17.1
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.1.37

License audit

NOT SAFE TO PUBLISH

Reason. The MACULA-Greek citations (CC-BY-NC-4.0) carry the token-level morphology and gloss for the 'to be impossible' (adynateo) construction at Luke 1:37, the 'all things are possible with God' (panta dynata para to theo) construction at Mark 10:27, and the 'ruler of all' (pantokrator) title with its Louw-Nida domain at Revelation 19:6, so that source is cited honestly and is not bulk-redistributable.

Source	License	Redistribute
OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

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